

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | SATURDAY, APRIL 25, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

“I know this team has a lot of history. It’s been awesome to kind of see that displayed as you walk through the building. I’m just happy to get in and get to work.”

DILLON THIENEMAN, an Oregon safety the Bears drafted in the first round on Thursday



HE’S ‘OBSESSED WITH FOOTBALL’

A narrower draft board led Bears to Dillon Thieneman, an Oregon safety who plays with ‘violent’ exuberance

By Sean Hammond | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Chicago Bears know who they are. Or at least, they know who they want to be.

Since coach Ben Johnson arrived a little more than a year ago, his vision and decisiveness have helped give the Bears front office a clear picture of the type of players who fit his team.

“This staff is unbelievable with just giving clarity,” Bears general manager Ryan Poles said. “And I think as we continue to work with each other, we’re going to know exactly what we’re looking for. So why mess around with (players) that don’t fit what we’re trying to do?”

The Bears didn’t on Thursday night when they selected Oregon safety Dillon Thieneman with the No. 25 pick in the NFL draft.

“This guy’s obsessed with football, he plays fast, he’s extremely fast, a great leader, violent in the way that he plays the game — everything that we’re looking for,” Poles said.

Behind Johnson’s vision, the Bears made a change this year. They went into draft week with a narrower list of players to target. Other teams might look at the board in the Bears draft room at Halas Hall and say it looked thin. That was just fine with Poles and Johnson.

“Our scouts do an unbelievable job gathering information, and then our coaching staff’s really clear what they’re looking for,” Poles said. “So it’s a really good marriage.”

The Bears had a need at safety. Both starting safeties from last season left in free agency — Kevin Byard to the New England Patriots and Jaquan Brisker to

See **DRAFT** on Page A4

Above: New Chicago Bears safety Dillon Thieneman speaks at his introductory news conference at Halas Hall on Friday in Lake Forest. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



NFL DRAFT
Saturday’s Rounds 4-7: 11 a.m. **TV:** ABC-7, ESPN, NFL Network
Inside: The best player on the Bears board intersected with what has been a clear need all offseason, and that ought to provide defensive coordinator Dennis Allen a world of options, writes Brad Biggs. **Sports**

CTA breaks ground on Red Line Extension

By Talia Soglin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Chicago Transit Authority on Friday officially began construction on a \$5.75 billion rail extension that will bring CTA train service to the city’s Far South Side.

Discussed for more than 50 years, the project is set to extend the CTA’s Red Line from its current terminus at 95th Street to 130th Street and add four new train stations along the way. The project could bring much-needed development to Far South Side neighborhoods and “undo nearly 60 years of racial inequity in transit,” in the words of former CTA President Dorval Carter.

But it’s also been criticized for its massive price tag, with cost estimates that have ballooned from \$3.6 billion just two years ago.

On Friday, officials cast the project as a long-overdue investment on the Far South Side.

“This project doesn’t just make history, it



Graham Garfield, dressed in a 1969 Chicago Transit Authority uniform, attends a ceremonial groundbreaking event at 115th Street and Michigan Avenue in Chicago on Friday to mark the start of the multibillion-dollar Red Line Extension project. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

corrects it,” said acting CTA President Nora Leerhsen during remarks at the afternoon ceremony.

“In our city and in our nation, we are plagued by a long past of decisions that deepened our divisions and entrenched inequality,” Leerhsen said. “Until now, the map of CTA’s of train lines told that story.”

The project faced a major hurdle last fall, when President Donald Trump’s administration froze nearly \$2 billion in federal

grant money the CTA needs to complete the project, citing an investigation into racial preferences in contracting.

For months, with early site preparation work underway on the Far South Side, the transit agency was unable to access federal reimbursements to pay for that work.

A federal judge last month ordered the feds to temporarily unfreeze those dollars,

See **CTA** on Page A2

Alleged ‘alliance’ with feds draws ire

O’Neill Burke’s office failed to prosecute blitz misdeeds, civil rights attorneys argue

By Madeline Buckley
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Cook County State’s Attorney Eileen O’Neill Burke has a “political alliance” with federal law enforcement that has hindered her office from investigating alleged wrongdoing by federal agents during Operation Midway Blitz, attorneys alleged Friday while asking a judge



O’Neill Burke

to appoint an independent special prosecutor.

As part of an effort by community members to hold federal immigration agents accountable, a coalition of organizations, politicians, clergy, and city and suburban residents packed into a courtroom at the Leighton Criminal Court Building to hear arguments over a petition filed in March in Cook County Circuit Court that asks a judge to appoint a special prosecutor to potentially prosecute immigration agents for their actions during the Trump administration’s controversial immigration enforcement operation last fall.

During the proceedings before Judge Erica Reddick, attorneys for the civil rights firm Loevy & Loevy drew comparisons to the appointment of special prosecutor who won a murder conviction against former Chicago police Officer Jason Van Dyke in the fatal shooting of 17-year-old Laquan McDonald, while also proffering an internal email they said was evidence of the office’s deference to federal law enforcement agencies when it did not

See **BLITZ** on Page A2

WHAT’S NEXT: A judge will rule next month whether to appoint a special prosecutor to potentially prosecute immigration agents for their actions during the Trump administration’s Midway Blitz operation last fall.

DOJ drops prosecution of Fed chair

Move clears way for vote on Powell’s potential successor

By Christopher Rugaber
and Eric Tucker
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The Justice Department has ended its investigation into Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell, clearing a major roadblock to the confirmation of Kevin Warsh as his successor.

U.S. Attorney for the District of Columbia Jeanine Pirro said on X Friday that her office was ending its probe into the Fed’s extensive building renovations because the Fed’s inspector general would scrutinize them instead.

The move could lead to a swift confirmation vote by the Senate for Warsh, a former top Fed official whom President Donald Trump, a Republican, nominated in January to replace Powell. Powell’s term as chair ends May 15.

Sen. Thom Tillis, a North Carolina Republican, had said he would oppose Warsh until the investigation was resolved, effectively blocking his confirmation.

Republicans praised Warsh during a Tuesday hearing even as Democrats questioned his independence from Trump, the lack of transparency around some of his financial holdings, and what they said was his flip-flopping on interest rates. Still, Trump’s previous appointment

See **POWELL** on Page A6

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY
H: 61
L: 44
SUN.
H: 64
L: 52
MON.
H: 73
L: 51
Complete details on Page A8

INDEX

Almanac A6
Arts & Living B7
Comics B10-11
Crossword B11
Editorials A5
Horoscope B10

Nation & World B4
Sudoku B11
Television B9

178th year No. 115
© Chicago Tribune

